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CURRENT SITUATION

In Myanmar the preconditions for genocide are now firmly in place. Racism has been normalised among the ethnically Burman population and the Rohingyas have already been subject to communal violence, state oppression and have been forced into both internal and external exile. Anti-Rohingya sentiment has been deliberately stoked up by a series of regimes since Burma gained independence. And most of the waves of anti-Rohingya violence have either been orchestrated by the state or have seen the officials of the state acting in close cooperation with other ethnic or religious groups.

A powerless minority is the victim of effective ethnic cleansing, in an environment where they are hated by their neighbours and actively discriminated against by state authorities. The situation is stark. Rohingya human rights activist Tun Khin has said, ‘We fear we will be wiped out’. Given the importance of preparing the ground for genocide, in terms of creating a particular set of social attitudes, his conclusion should be a warning to the world: ‘in the case of inhumanity and injustice, no one should be silent. What’s happening to us requires a serious kind of humanity—this is a very important moment for Rohingya’.[1]

There has been no improvement since 2004 when Barbara Harff argued that Myanmar was the state in the world most at risk of genocide.[2] Indeed, with the recent waves of violence, the situation has palpably worsened. According to United to End Genocide, ‘nowhere in the world are there more known precursors to genocide than in Burma today’.[3] The Early Warning Project identified Myanmar in 2015 as the state in the world most at risk,[4] above countries such as Sudan, Nigeria and the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which all receive more international attention.